7.7 Walk the rhythm



Learning goals

Students

- Understands how rhythmic patterns relate to the underlying metre
- Connect movement patterns to expressive phrasing.
- Switches fluently between different movement or musical patterns within a stable metre.

Requirements

- Space
- Possibly accompaniment music or accompaniment instrument (piano, djembe, guitar, etc.)

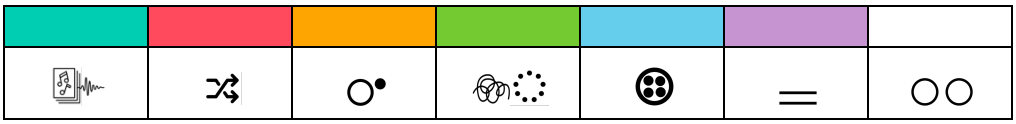
Inspiration

This activity is inspired by the Dalcroze approach, in which it is customary to step to music while expressing musical structures or elements. A second source of inspiration is the use of arsis (on time) and thesis (on the beat). Finally, there is also the work of Pedro Alcan-tara, who uses the principle of stressed and unstressed feet in language to develop musical expressiveness.

Read more ...
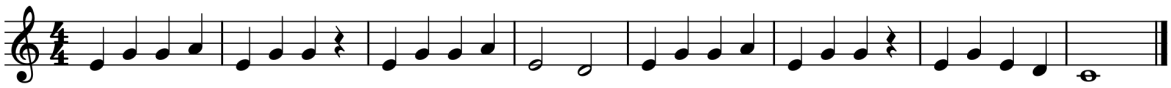
De Alcantara, P. (2011). *Integrated practice: coordination, rhythm & sound*. Oxford University Press.

Constraints



Description

In this exercise, a rhythmic pattern is taught, for example in preparation for the song *Great big house*.



There are three patterns in this song:



For each musical pattern, find a movement pattern. For example:

	4 steps forward for the first measure, 1 step forward and 3 backward for the second measure
	4 steps forward for the first measure, 2 times sliding forward for the second measure
	4 steps forward for the first measure, turn on the spot for the second measure (while taking four small steps)

Practice each rhythmic pattern separately first, without playing.

Helpful tip: have students first step a specific pattern while saying aloud what they are doing. For example:



“1 2 3 4 forth and back”



“1 2 3 4 slide slide”



“1 2 3 4 turg_____ning”

Each movement pattern can then be combined with playing a musical rhythmic pattern.

Variations

- Walking freely around the space, walking around in a circle
- Switch between 'mechanical' and 'expressive' steps per step pattern, possibly linked to a spatial choreography per step pattern. For example: mechanical steps in a circle, expressive free movement around the room

  Tip: Sometimes it can be difficult, especially for younger students, to understand the concept of 'expressive' and translate it into a way of moving. One way to address this is to ask the children to move in a 'funny' way, or to regularly express other things through movement, such as emotions, robot vs. rag doll, etc

- Combine the previous variation with the activity 'Freeze!'
- Students switch between rhythmic patterns in their steps (e.g., ♩♩♩♩ |♩♩♩𝄽) and playing the counts on the instrument (♩♩♩♩|♩♩♩♩), and rhythmic patterns in their music-making (e.g., ♩♩♩♩ |♩♩♩𝄽) and stepping the counts (♩♩♩♩|♩♩♩♩).
- Students switch between stepping in place (personal space) and stepping around the classroom (external space).
- Students find their own stepping pattern for each musical pattern.